

See also: The Metropolitan Police Act 140–143 ■ The United Nations and International Court of Justice 212–219
■ The European Convention on Human Rights 230–233 ■ The European Court of Justice 234–241

“

Our collective goal must be to turn corruption into a high-risk, low-profit activity.

Jürgen Stock

INTERPOL secretary general, 2016

”

police professionals, it set out 12 key wishes that would later help lay the groundwork for the creation of INTERPOL.

The ICPC

Progress was interrupted by World War I, but police officials from 15 countries met at the International Criminal Police Congress in Vienna in 1923. This conference set up the International Criminal Police Commission (ICPC) to implement the 12 wishes, but cross-border cooperation on identification of criminals was at its heart. Original members included Austria, Germany, Belgium, China, France, Italy, and Yugoslavia. The UK joined in 1928, but the US did not join for another 15 years.

In 1933, the ICPC was officially recognized by the League of Nations. But by this time, politics was already influencing who was targeted as international criminals by the ICPC. For example, during the first half of the 1930s, many nations in the West thought that the chief fight was against communists. When Nazi Germany

annexed Austria in 1938, most countries withdrew from the ICPC and it became dominated by high-ranking SS officers. Its headquarters moved from Vienna to Berlin in 1942, where it was used by the Gestapo to target Jews, gypsies, and other minorities.

INTERPOL and Europol

After World War II, police officials from 17 countries met to revive the organization, which was tainted by Nazism and had lost most of its records. It moved to Paris in 1946 and started from scratch: Article 1 of its new constitution stressed fighting “ordinary” crime, aiming to exclude any offenses with a political, religious, or racial basis. The name INTERPOL was adopted in 1956. While it has no policing power in any participating countries, its work to provide investigative support and aid cooperation between law enforcement agencies has helped raise membership to 194 by the early 21st century.

In 1975, European police forces boosted their cooperation to combat terrorism with the TREVI group. (This French acronym stands for “terrorism, radicalism, extremism, and international violence.”) When the Schengen agreements allowed freedom of movement between signatory countries, European police forces began to work even more closely, and in 1992, the European Police Office (Europol) was set up in The Hague. Originally intended as a drug unit, it has expanded its brief, particularly toward organized crime that crosses national borders, including human trafficking, money laundering, and child exploitation.

Many countries fiercely guard their borders and their own way of dealing with offenders. INTERPOL’s powers remain limited, and extraditions (sending citizens to another country to face trial) are often the subject of disputes. But the principle of cooperation between police forces worldwide is now widely accepted. ■

Categories of crime pursued by INTERPOL



Terrorism and crimes against people and property

Includes crimes against children, human trafficking, terrorist plots, illegal immigration, automobile theft, and art theft.



Economic, financial, and computer crimes

Includes banking fraud, money laundering, corruption, counterfeiting, and fraud involving travel documents.



Illegal drugs and criminal organizations

Includes offenses carried out by international drug cartels, the Mafia, and terrorist organizations.